The similarities in the later legend around Ashoka and the story of Harsha—neither of whom were the oldest sons of their fathers and thus not rightful heirs to the throne—is striking. In both instances we have odd signs connected with pregnant queens, as also a figure who had powerful insights into what such signs meant. This is, in brief, the characteristic narrative mode of a culture in which the sacred is regularly smuggled into the picture in the shape of a prophecy, the function of such prophecy being to bestow legitimacy on an ascension otherwise dubious.

Now it is time to travel to Pataliputra, the city of Ashoka's childhood and of his later years. Not everything about the period of this future emperor needs to be extracted from legitimizing lore constructed hundreds of years after his death. Unlike the emperor himself, the character and culture of Pataliputra can be reconstructed from clues that are contemporary with Mauryan times. Through them one may come closer to an understanding of Ashoka's early life. As for whether Ashoka's future was actually predicted in this court, we will never know. All we can safely say is that, in this time of the late centuries BCE in North India, such a prophecy would not have surprised anyone.